

Home away from home: Morocco captain Achraf Hakimi, born in Spain, and France midfielder Michael Olise, born in England, were among those who proved that football makes borders irrelevant. AFP

reshaped not just nations, but the beautiful game itself.

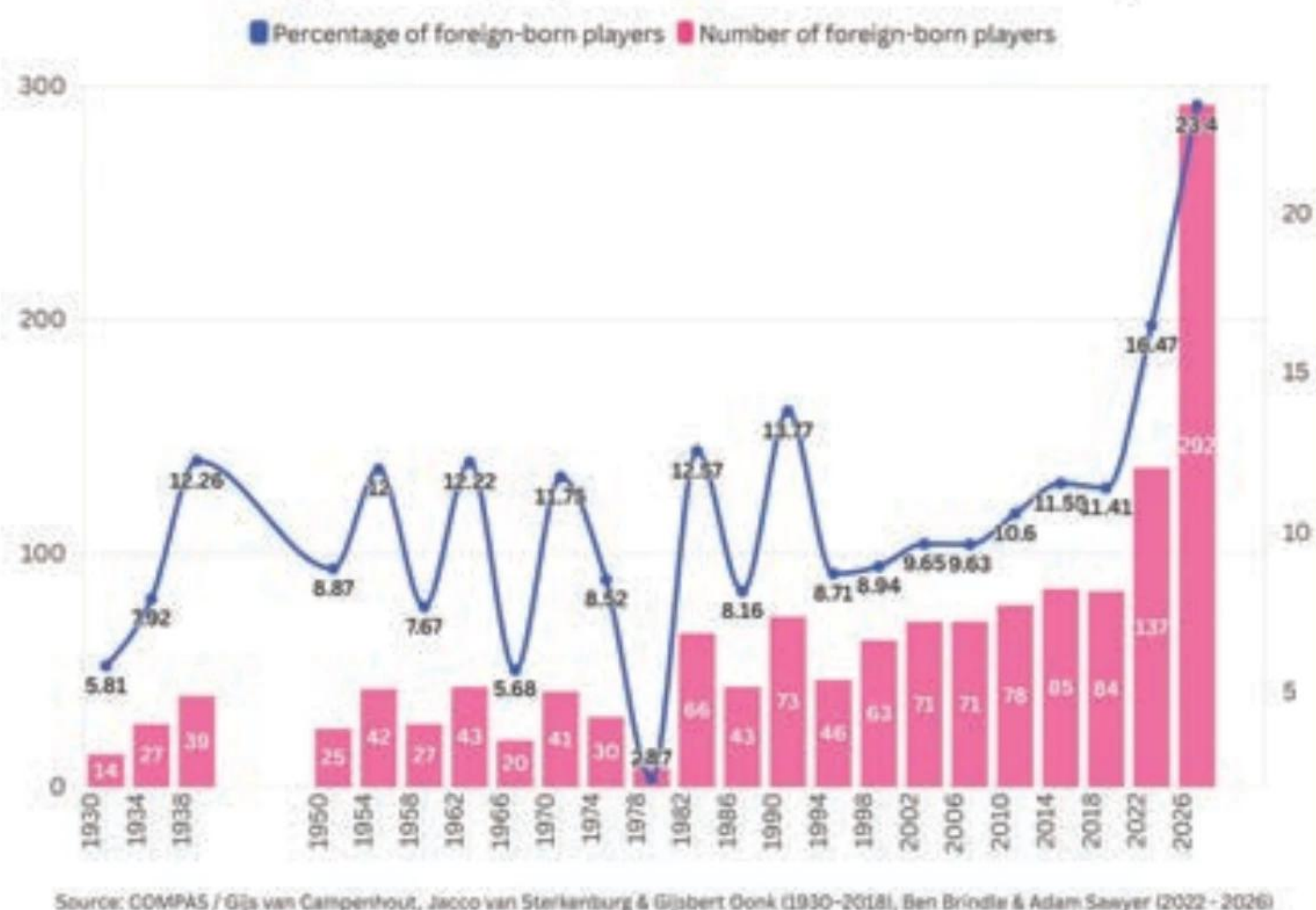
No edition of the FIFA World Cup has featured as many foreign-born players as the 2026 tournament, with only eight of the 48 teams fielding squads made up entirely of home-born players.

Nestory Irankunda, born in a refugee camp in Tanzania before moving to Australia, scored the Socceroos' first goal of the tournament, becoming their youngest-ever World Cup goalscorer. Ibrahim Mbaye, meanwhile, became Africa's youngest World Cup goalscorer after the France-born forward scored for Senegal against the country of his birth.

Record numbers

According to a study by the Centre on Migration, Policy and Society (COMPAS), nearly one in four players at this World Cup represented a country different from the one in which they were born. Compared to the previous edition, that marks a 40 per cent increase — a tournament record.

Foreign-born players in the FIFA World Cup



Debutant Curacao is a striking example of this. All but one of its players — Tahith Chong — were born in the Netherlands. So too was Sidny Lopes Cabral, who almost stunned defending champion Argentina with a jaw-dropping goal for Cape Verde.

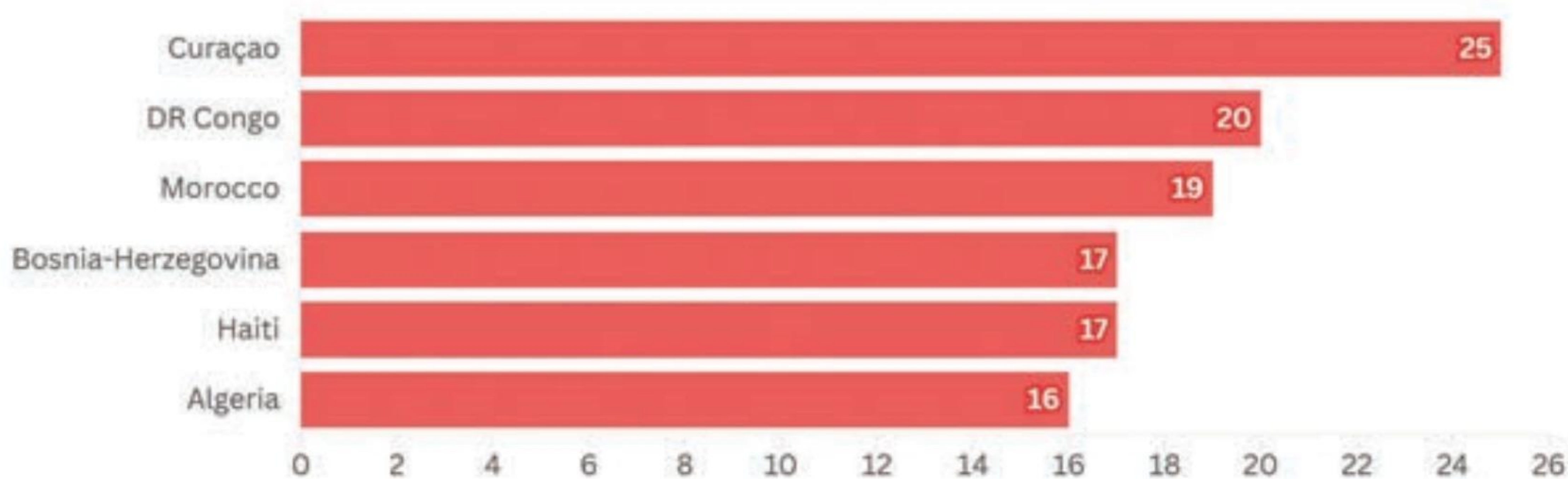
FIFA has been refining its rules in this regard since 1960, with players now allowed to switch national allegiance through lineage or naturalisation only once.

A player can also switch national teams after representing another country, provided those appearances

were not in senior competitive matches. That allowed Declan Rice to switch from Ireland to England and Diego Costa from Brazil to Spain.

Switching national allegiances has also produced unique examples of brothers or half-brothers representing different countries this World Cup. Such as Harry and John Souttar (Australia and Scotland), Desire and Guela Doue (France and Ivory Coast), Nico and Iñaki Williams (Spain and Ghana), and half-brothers Derrick Luckassen and Brian Brobbey (Ghana and the Netherlands).

Squads with most foreign-born players in 2026 World Cup



Source: Opta